

cessful.
Then why sign a deal with Microsoft at all? No matter how you look at it, exclusivity seems like a loss for Square. They may get a boost in sales once the game releases for the PlayStation this October, but the game is a year old now, the hype is gone. Sure the plan was to compete with Uncharted but it didn't even manage to do that, in fact, Uncharted sold three times more than Rise of the Tomb Raider did in its first month.

However, this can work the other way around as well. When a hardware company signs an exclusivity deal with a third party game developer, this could be a boon for the game developer as well. Developing a game is not cheap, popular game devs can get by but others could be in quite the pinch. This was especially prominent when crowdfunding wasn't as big as it is today. By signing an exclusivity deal, not only do they get the funding from the hardware company to be able to create the game they way they want to, the hardware company will also market and push their game for them. Simply because doing so is an asset for them as well.

Let's take a look at one of the planned Xbox One exclusive releases, Cuphead. Cuphead is a platformer – since retro games seem to be all the rage right now – and from the looks of it, a really good one, though we don't know that yet. Does it look good enough to warrant buying an Xbox just to play it? Err, maybe not, but we get it on PC anyway so that's not the point here. People on the PlayStation don't get to play Cuphead, but they might actually want to play the game if it turns out to be good. The funding one gets from signing exclusivity is no small amount, it can actually significantly

affect the quality of the game itself. Now Cuphead was originally set to be a small indie game according to the developers. Nothing too complex, a few bosses here and there, they were only a three-man team after all, what more could they do? But thanks to Microsoft, they were able to create the game without any limitation, in all its glory so to speak. So yea, Sony fans won't get to play Cuphead, which sucks for them. But those who do get to play Cuphead should be able to enjoy a full experience, which otherwise wouldn't have been possible if it weren't for the funding they received from Microsoft. So in short, for smaller developers, signing an exclusivity deal could be the difference between success and failure.

Final verdict?

So in conclusion, what can we derive from this? Ultimately, it's all about the money. The reason any company would sign an exclusivity deal is

because they believe that they would make more money out of it. They don't have to spend more money on developing other versions of the game for other consoles. It's a trade-off. A gamble. A double-edged sword. Which is something companies have to take from time to time, a risk. But AAA companies don't really have to take that risk or make that gamble. It makes absolutely no sense for third party AAA companies to make their games console exclusive unless they're getting an absurdly large amount of money from the hardware company in question. The console company has to make an offer that will offset the losses that the developer might incur because of making the game an exclusive, and in case of AAA titles, this will be a HUGE amount.

No true gamer likes exclusivity. Everyone would love to play 'em all. So if the world could do away with exclusivity, that would be nice. Thanks. *



Sometimes console exclusivity deals can also give wings to a small team of game devs or a studio that has the talent but can't attain its full potential. Just see what happened to Cuphead, an Xbox One exclusive release. Too bad PS and PC players won't get to play it, but because of Microsoft's funding, Cuphead truly realized its potential. That ain't so bad now, is it?